Chiaroscuro

By Lisa Dillman

INTRODUCTION

Chiaroscuro *is a term in art for a contrast between light and dark. The term is usually applied to bold contrasts affecting a whole composition. From the perspective of Lisa Dillman, it is the perfect word to describe the before and after of Alzheimer's Disease.*

When Alzheimer's disease begins to destroy brain cells, no outward symptoms are evident. After a while, small memory lapses appear and grow more serious. The afflicted individual may forget the names of familiar people or places, the words to express what they want to say, or the location of everyday objects. For a mother and daughter who built their relationship on the power of words, the loss of verbal ability is even more devastating. Chiaroscuro by Lisa Dillman

JEN: In the beginning. A woman with red, red lipstick and a voice full of jumps and trills and wonder tells me story after story night after night.

MOTHER: " . . . Soon the princess came to a clearing in the woods. And there, hunched upon a craggy stump, sat a gnome of questionable breeding. He had a wart the size of an egg on the tip of his nose and he was hairy from top to toe. Some might call him matted. He took one look at our princess and found her so enticing that for a moment he was tempted not to put a curse on her. But alas! Evil gnome tradition won the day. 'Oh, thou pretty aimless wench. Sit ye on my splintery bench. Bethink all words ye've spake before. From this day on ye'll speak no more.'"

JEN: Later . . . She and my stepfather yak away all through dinner – their conversations, their banter erupting out of them, surging, blasting,

spluttering. They warble. They chortle. They tease. They research and excavate each other's day. Words are king and queen and the rest of the royal family too. Words are the real food; what's on their plates is just an excuse. During a pause that many wouldn't recognize as such, I break in. "Hey, what's that? What's chiaroscuro?" They look perplexed for a moment – Did you just hear something? What was that sound? -- and, squinting, tell me I'd better just go look it up.

MOTHER: Keep up or give up.

JEN: I begin bringing the dictionary to the table with me. With the extra four inches, I am almost as tall as they are. It's massive, a weighty tome – an abridged OED. Abridged, yes, but that's OK by me – it's the perfect height and I like the elevation. I hop on and off it at will, finding, then absorbing the words. The words. Torrents, deluges of them. Great avalanches and whirling siroccos of words. Words all day and late into the night. I believe God invented sleeping just to shut us up a while. Later . . . We play Poem-itation.

MOTHER: Whose socks these are I think I know . . . She's chucked them on the sofa though. (Barest pause.)

JEN: But Ma won't mid I leave them there . . . Since I'm a lazy so-and-so.

MOTHER: And yet she does not think it queer . . . To always lob her socks right there.

JEN: One: split infinitive. Two: Frost is too easy. And while we're at it, Gray's Elegy blows big juicy chunks.

MOTHER: There stands and sneers the tiny-minded queen . . . it's true she knows it all at age thirteen . . .

JEN: I'm only twelve.

MOTHER: Don't mess with meter (Regroups.) Tom Gray is not a chucklefest, it's true . . . Still, he's a well-loved poet, unlike you.

JEN: Talk is incessant. Silence means you have nothing to say. Of course there are things we don't talk about. (She sneak a glance at Mother, who stands rubbing her temples gently, in obvious pain.) And times when all talk suddenly ceases for days on end. And question marks bank up in the corners of the rooms. When my mother wanders the house noiselessly through the night. Then sleeps in patches through the following day in her shaded room, with the door closed and locked. And if I have to ask her something . . . (She taps the floor lightly with her foot – a knock)

MOTHER: What?

JEN: Absolute specificity is vital. Or she will whimper and gnash at her pillow. (Beat. Then with great deliberation). I was hoping I could borrow your car. For tonight. To leave approximately seven p.m. and return at midnight or before. With no driving over sixty-five miles per hour on the highways - - certainly much less than that on the byways – an no alcohol or drug consumption taking place during the hours the car is entrusted to my care (Beat.)

MOTHER: Take it.

JEN: Later . . . My stepfather takes his leave. Conversation-wise he'd already been gone a while. Dinners had become cacophonous with the sounds of mastication – his and mine, usually, since my mother was so often among the disappeared. His voiceless but very present wish to

be elsewhere sucked all words out of the dinner hour. I took the opportunity to catalog his faults. His baldness. His lack of energy. His haunted, hopeless eyes. His habit of sniffing the back of his hand. Obsessively. But most of all, his silence. There he sat – balding, sniffing inertia personified. A husk. Then on e evening he didn't come to the table. And soon it was apparent he'd cleared out for good. Later. . . My mother returns to the world. She drinks more wine than before. We play Limerick Impromptu.

MOTHER: There once was a man from Toledo . . . Who looked awfully good in his Speedo . . . He'd prance all around . . . Then pull the thing down . . While the ladies all swooned, "Oh how neato!"

JEN: Aren't you bawdy.

MOTHER: Limericks are traditionally filthy. I cleaned it up because we're eating. Your turn. Go ahead.

JEN: I'd rather not.

MOTHER: Oh, come on!

JEN: There once was a mom from Seattle . . . About the male member she'd prattle . . . She'd slurp up her wine . . . Then sit there and pine . . . 'Cuz finding a man's such a battle.

MOTHER: There once was a mean, heartless daughter . . .

JEN: Yes?

MOTHER: That's enough for tonight. Consume your comestibles, you.

JEN: Meaning she's had enough to drink that the necessary end rhymes would be an impossible feat. Meaning I hurt her feelings. Meaning something else too. Something so integral to our relationship that I

can't name it until years later: I bore her. The occasional limerick is a poor replacement for densely layered stories from the heady landscape of my school day. Since she can build an epic out of a fifteen-minute to the grocery store, she can't see why I don't do the same. She figures that I must be living the life of a veritable Candide out there in the world. And what a withholding little gob-shite I am for not laying out the rich tapestry of my misadventures. The truth is I'm not picaresque. And words don't thrill me anymore.

MOTHER: Oh, Jen! Tell Marcia about that Dickensian math teacher of yours! She does a drop-dead impression of this guy, Marcia. Go on, honey. Tell it.

JEN: You tell it. (Mother turns away. With great animation she silently mimes the impression and tells the story.) And then she does. And she tells it better than I could have. And she imitates the math teacher – she's only met him once – better than I can after having sat in his class a semester and a half.

MOTHER: I've just about decided you're shy.

JEN: Well, I'm not.

MOTHER: You won't let anyone know you.

JEN: You know me.

MOTHER: Is that true, sweetie? Do I know you? (Beat.)

JEN: Don't you? (Beat.) Later (Beat.) Years later. I am home. Alone. It's been a long day. My feet hurt. I'm on my third glass of merlot. The phone.

MOTHER: It's me.

JEN: Hello, you.

MOTHER: Listen . . . do you . . . ? What does splungeree mean?

JEN: Umm. Something to do with exploring caves?

MOTHER: I'm not sure.

JEN: Well, where di you hear it? Give me some context.

MOTHER: I went to the door to see the postman today, and when he forked over my mail I said to him, "Oh, nuts. Just a bunch of splungeree." (Jen laughs). I couldn't think of the word for catalogs. I was standing there with a fistful of the things and I couldn't think of the word. Splungeree. I went inside and wrote it down. I had to sit and meditate to get the word catalog to come back to me. It was floating out there in the mist for such a long time.

JEN: Later.

MOTHER: It happened again.

JEN: We began to keep a list. We call it the List in the Mist. Splungeree. Altocram. Zlit. Oppley.

MOTHER: Eggoline. Fedabush. Croomuttle.

JEN: Hohorgan. Denkaptu. Argenbach. Joroist.

MOTHER: Cabblefan. Chickley. That thing you boil water in. The trattalot. I can't remember anything. I burned the bottom out of my trattalot this morning.

JEN: We play List/Mist/Gist (Reciting.) In last week's o'erlooked splungeree . . . I found a trattalot . . . I knew it was the one for me . . . I'd wrecked my old teapot.

MOTHER: A teapot . . the word comes to me . . . not always, but just now . . .

JEN: I long to make a spot of tea . . . But I've forgotten how (Beat.) Later. A specialist informs her she's suffered a series of tiny strokes. Probably over a period of years. Painless. But finally measurable.

MOTHER: Don't let me get away with anything. Correct me. Tell me what it's supposed to be.

JEN: Yes. I will . Later . . . She gives up driving and spends most of her time in her garden. Her conversation for the most part makes sense. But she speaks in facts now.

MOTHER: It's your. Birthday. I sent you a card.

JEN: And then there are the holes. The ones less and less-often filled by even her transitory invented language.

MOTHER: Today I . . . sssssss. . . I . . . ohhh. Nothing.

JEN: I think of her often just before sleep But she is young and her red, red mouth is a vivid patch in perpetual motion. I see her take a step away from me. Waving. And then another. Still waving.

MOTHER: The lilacs. Are early this year.

JEN: And the mist rolls up around her feet. She is blurred around the edges. But still she is waving.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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